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Orrin Evans

Pianist Orrin Evans has excelled as a sideman and a leader during his twenty year career. He has recorded twenty five albums to date and his diverse offerings can be explained in his own words: "I go head first for a lot of things." Orrin became the new pianist for the Bad Plus in January of 2018.

Orrin was interviewed in Utica, New York on May 22, 2018 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have Orrin Evans with me today. And you are a well-traveled performer, but I think I can safely say you've never been in this particular spot before.

OE: I can agree. I mean as far as New York goes, for me, definitely the city, I've been to Albany and Corning, but this is my first time here.

MR: In Utica, New York. And looking forward to the performance tonight. You'll be playing with some people you know, but some that you don't.

OE: Um hum.

MR: Audience members are sometimes intrigued by that. How do you put on what can look like a rehearsed or like you're a band, and you're not really a band. How does that work?

OE: Well we are a band for tonight. And you know I do hear that a lot, "Oh you've just joined them and you guys just met?" Those kinds of things. But I guess that's what we've been doing all our lives practicing and practicing performing music, so then if you're all speaking that same language, you know, and that language is the language of music, it's really easy to sit down and play with some people that speak the same language. Now sometimes things happen where we might speak a different dialect. You know we're still speaking the same language but you can tell, "Oh you're from North Philly. Oh you're from the Bronx. Oh you're from down —" You know, and you have a different swagger about you. So when you play with a new band, for me that's what it is. No matter what the conversation is going to happen, because we're all speaking the same language. No different than us right now. But because I'm from Philly and Reggie's West Virginia, and we have all these different places, the fun part is figuring out how — we speak the same language and we understand each other's slang and stuff. That's the fun part of it.

MR: There's a certain etiquette to a jazz performance. Can you learn that in jazz school?

OE: It depends on who you're learning from you know. I mean when you think about people who teach the business of music, if there is a course offered wherever you are and they have a business of music course, sometimes it's taught by someone who had four gigs before they got that position. You know? And sometimes it's taught by someone who's

had, you know, a touring career already. So they can share things that the other person didn't know, or doesn't know. So really it just depends on who you're learning from in school. Now if you're out in the world, because I always say I went to the university of the streets. Because I went to Rutgers University but I learned so much from just playing and being a part of the scene and from people like Bobby Watson and Ralph Peterson, Ralph Bowen and all these, Shirley Scott, Trudy Pitts, just people that I was around in the neighborhood. And being in the street. Being on the bandstand. Being out there checking it out. So there are some things you can learn and if you have the right professor, someone like Ralph Peterson who teaches at Berklee University, I mean Berklee College of Music, they're getting the best of both worlds. He's toured the world and now he's teaching. And he's still touring the world. So those students are going to get some of the things that the other students might not get.

MR: I was looking at your website which is very informative, and it's clear to me that the music you create didn't come out of a vacuum. You mentioned your parents were artistic and can you tell me about your home atmosphere and how it might have affected your career path?

OE: Well first, my father was a playwright and a full time teacher teaching African-American studies for 35 years. He taught at Princeton, taught at Trenton State, and taught at Rutgers, one of the reasons I went to Rutgers. He wasn't there when I went there but that's one of the reasons. So that, I got the best of both worlds in that situation because my father was an artist. He was a playwright. And he also taught school. So I had the importance of education but I also was like hanging out with him at different events and meeting some great actors and I just had a really good time being a part of that. And on top of that, my mother was an opera singer and also an educator. So I grew up in that environment and they stressed the importance of the arts. You know we would have little cabarets in the house where my mother would invite a piano player and she'd sing and they'd have parties in the house. And it was like little nightclubs. My mom would make little card tables, you know, and put them around the house. That kind of attention to detail too is something I really gathered from both of my parents you know. And it just was a great environment to grow up in. And even my parents ended up getting divorced when I was maybe eleven or twelve, but still, you know, that was already in there and my parents still came to all my gigs and were so supportive. So I really had a great time growing up contrary to what people may think from a broken home per se. But I guess the best way is the home never broke. It never really — and I had my brother who had introduced me to a lot of music and then my sister, who between dance and acting and now as a high school principal. So everything was happening around us. The only thing

that wasn't happening was my dad wasn't fixing too much stuff. He wasn't that kind of dad. There were a bunch of projects around the house.

MR: I can relate to that.

OE: Exactly. That's why I call contractors, man.

MR: The part about, you said your brother used to take you on his bike to your first piano lessons and it got me thinking about piano lessons and how they relate and I wonder, can you recall when you first encountered chord symbols and then what do I do with these?

OE: Without a doubt. You know my mother, jazz was a reward for practicing. Because I just wanted to go straight to jazz. And she was like no, you're going to do this, you're going to study classical, blah blah blah. And then you can play jazz. Which was kind of, when I look back on it, it really put the foundation in me for musical theory and different things like that. And then I played a little bit of organ at the church around the corner, at a Lutheran church, so this was a pipe organ when I was still a teenager. So while I was doing that, that's when I guess you could say the jazz bug bit me. Because I would hear it but it was through the theater and musicals. So I would hear certain songs and then I'm like well wait a minute, that sounds like this you know. Or I would hear my mother sing "My Funny Valentine," but my mother singing "My Funny Valentine" was very — she did the verse out front and everything, just like a production, it was a whole piece. But then I was like who's this? Miles Davis doing "My Funny Valentine"? But I didn't know how he did it like that and she did it like that. I just knew it was the same song. So my discovery of like chord changes and how these two things came together, my uncle was a New York street performer. And he started the street performers' union or whatever it was called. And he was also an actor and blah blah blah. So he did a one man show where he talked about his whole travels and traveling the world and being a musician. And he wrote this beautiful tune. And I wanted to play it. And I'm like, "Oh Uncle Ben, can you give me the music? Can you give me the music? Can you give me the music?" And you know he was like okay. And he was actually one of the ones who ended up paying for some of my piano lessons later on and guitar lessons. Like he was very supportive in my career. So I said great. And he gave me the music. And when I got the music I said what is this. I had no idea. I go wait a minute, there's nothing here you know. And there was chord changes and the melody.

MR: Like a lead sheet.

OE: Like a lead sheet. And it had some other little — but I was like this is not what I heard them play you know. And that was my first intro into what a lead sheet was and what the chord changes were. So what I did was I still didn't get it but I was studying at a school called Girard Academic Music Program. And at that school theory was like a major subject, music theory. So I had music theory and we started talking about intervals and

different things. It still didn't have the answer for me but I'm looking at different things and I'm finding oh this is major, this is minor. And I remember I was sitting downstairs and I looked at the sheet of music and I was like, "I've got it!" You know I didn't have it all right but I had figured out okay when it says F something, you make an F chord. Now then I had to discover major, minor, diminished. But that was my intro into what a lead sheet was. And I just took the theory I was learning at GAMP and applied it to it in the beginning of that.

MR: Did it help that, I would guess in your classical study you had learned your scales. So that must have helped when you go to figure out the chords. Right?

OE: Definitely. Definitely. And then once I got to Rutgers University, studying with Ralph Bowen, I learned, I was coming from a major/minor world. That's all. It was like major, minor, maybe a diminished. Like that's all I really knew about. And he opened my ears and my mind up to a whole world of sound and sound possibilities through building them in a scale. And I still go back to it. You play it but it's good to go back to it and just like study it again. Because then it comes out a different way. Because you're a different person, I'm definitely not the same person that I was at 18. So now going back and looking at some of that material and then applying it to what I'm playing now, you know, it's a constant evolution.

MR: Yeah. Evolution, and your "I got it" moment with your chords, did you have a similar moment with your career or was it more of a gradual, maybe I can do this?

OE: Well I will say I, you know, I say this and like my wife and I went to this marriage class. It was at a church that my sister was going to, that she still does go to and we were going to it a little bit around that time too. So it was a fun class and you had homework and everything. And there were maybe ten or twelve couples in there. But one of the things that stuck out like the first day was like divorce is not an option. Like if you're taking this class divorce is not an option. And I always loved that. So I apply that to my career. When people say well what would you — there is nothing else I've thought about doing. You know, not playing music was not an option. And I think the moment that I discovered I was going to do it, and it was something that I could make money from was the seventh grade, at that same school, Girard Academic Music Program. I had played and when I was living in New Jersey, because that's where I'm originally from, I had played piano and everything. But then when my parents split I moved to Philly with my mother. And we moved to this block that had no kids. But we came from a block that had kids every age all the way up. And I was always riding my bike, that's what I wanted to do. But when I moved to Philadelphia, in the sixth grade, and I started this school, the only thing I really could hang with was the piano. There were no kids on my block. I didn't know anybody so I was like what am I going to do. Well I know I can play the

piano a little bit. And I was playing the piano in Philly, I'm sorry, in New Jersey, so let me start messing around with this piano. And my uncle was a jazz saxophonist so that's what we were living with at the time. So when I got to Girard Academic Music Program that would be the moment when I got to this school where everyone was a performer, you know there were singers — it was like "Fame" you know, except there was no dancing in the hallways or anything. But it was definitely the moment where I was like wait a minute, this is what I want to do. Now I didn't know it was going to be jazz. I mean at that time I was thinking about conducting, I was thinking about going to Boston Conservatory, there were so many different things in that process.

MR: Were you influenced by the pop music of the day?

OE: Hmm. I had a quick answer and then I thought about it. It was a part of my life but the music I enjoyed playing and the music — I wasn't making a connection of New Edition and Coltrane at that time you know. I was just listening to John Coltrane or Miles or Oscar Peterson. And really I couldn't deal with John Coltrane at that age either. I wasn't ready. So I was like Oscar Peterson, just, and if the record had originals on it I couldn't listen. I didn't know. I had to relate it to the show tunes that my mother was telling me about. So I would only get records that had standards on them.

MR: Oh that's really interesting.

OE: Yeah. Because I couldn't really understand what was happening unless I could apply it, for me, something I knew. But the New Edition and Earth Wind and Fire and all those songs, that was like car music and cookout. I never really thought about hey I could play that tune in a jazz form. And now I'm doing it in the last ten years. I wish I really had thought about it honestly when I was younger but I didn't make that connection.

MR: That attachment to show tunes and tunes that are melodic and easily remembered, does that affect your own composition? Do you think about the audience and what are they hearing.

OE: Well I think the other tunes are extremely melodic and easy to digest too. I just didn't know how to do that at that young age. So, and it was more, sorry, it was less about it being easy to digest and more about me just being able to relate to it. You know, or could make a connection. So when I see Coltrane does "My Favorite Things" I say oh wow, and I go and check out, you know, like from the movie. You know what I mean? Or "All the Things You Are" and I'm like okay I know that, and I can apply it. So that was more that kind of thing. And then as time went on and my ears developed — well they're still developing — but my ears developed and I've said okay well let me try this. You know? And then I learned okay, this is what it is and that was probably "Kind of Blue." That was the first quote unquote jazz record I bought. You know it was definitely — there were some other ones but that was the one like I took a risk. Because there were no standards

on it, I didn't know anything on it. But I was relating it to modes. We were studying modes in school, in high school, or in middle school around that time, I said grab this record. So for me it was always just being able to connect it to something until I got older and I'm like I don't need to connect this I just need to enjoy what it is.

MR: Was there a particular tune on "Kind of Blue" that you latched on to?

OE: Yep. "Blue in Green."

MR: Most people probably would not pick that one.

OE: Yeah. That did for me one because of the intro and two, it's a very simple but complex harmonic progression in that tune. So I've always, I still love it, I still love it.

MR: So you didn't do the jazz education thing to a degree? To a terminal degree as they say is that right?

OE: No. I went to Rutgers for a year and a half and about halfway through my second year there was a club in Philadelphia called the Blue Moon. And they asked me to come manage it. And they were like, I was really into that part too like I mentioned earlier, the business of music too. So I was only nineteen managing and booking the club. I wasn't like the daytime man, I was just manager of the entertainment part. So I did sound, I booked artists. And then I'm not saying it was the best choice I ever made, but I will remember, it was like right before Christmas, and I'm doing what I want to do, I'm around music, and I'm getting paid every week. So I might as well go do this. And at that time, you know there were a lot of people, everybody moved to New York. And I hadn't moved to New York. So I really, Rutgers didn't seem like the place for me. And looking back I have no regrets you know, but it would have been nice to just finish the last two years. And as I look at my son now in his second year, finishing his second year of college, I was like whew — he made it. Because my wife also, we both left the second year. But she left the second year to go to Europe. So it's not like we're sitting like we should have — we had some pretty fun lives you know.

MR: Yeah. Parents like to say you can have a fall back on. You know, the old fall back on.

OE: Exactly.

MR: But when you described stepping into that role in that jazz club it made me think of these young men in college basketball and they can go into the NBA and do what they were intending to do all the way along, so why not.

OE: Exactly. Exactly.

MR: You've been a side person and then you've led your own groups. Sometimes I would guess more than one group at the same time. What does it take to be a leader these days?

OE: Honestly it takes a desire. That's the first thing. And then that same thing that we just talked about where we said I have no choice, divorce is not an option, I had no choice, that being if you really want to be a leader you have to have that same mentality. Like

there's nothing I want to do but lead. It doesn't mean you don't do other sideman gigs, you do those, but you have to decide that you're going to be, and want to be a leader. Because it's an entirely different ballgame.

MR: You must have a prerequisite it must be, that you have a vision for your music and this requires me to be a leader because I have an idea of what I want this music to sound like. Is that a fair statement?

OE: No. Because I think you can have an idea of what you want the music to sound like as a sideman you know. I mean I think a big part of it for me being a leader, I was always a creator. I wanted to create my own gigs, I wanted to — maybe it's the Aries in me where I needed to be in control. Whatever it is, I enjoyed that part. But it comes — it's not easy you know. I said around tax time this year, I said, you know because everybody says why don't you talk about the difference between the leader and the sideman. Look. You wait to tax time when you have to explain who you paid, how you paid them, you have to track all of that. There's not just oh I showed up and I had my tunes and I got to play them. I mean it's a whole different ballgame you know. You people when you're — a friend of mine said the other day, "I'm a bass player. You just call me and I show up." And I understood what he meant. As a sideman, he felt that for himself. I'm not saying I agree with that all the time. But sometimes as a sideman you learn the music and you show up. And I'm not saying that's easy, but that's what you do. As a leader sometimes you've got to write the music, show up, deal with the promoter, deal with the audience, you're trying to play the gig and you're watching the door to make sure you've got enough people to cover the — like all of that kind of stuff. And then you can deal with the music, which is not always — now I'm learning to manage and flip it you know what I mean? But it's not easy. It's not easy.

MR: And then at the end of the gig you're like hanging out to get paid and your side people are waiting to get paid. Yeah. There's a lot to it.

OE: Or now, like the world is, some people will say such-and-such doesn't call me anymore. They must not like playing with me or something like that. A sideman could possibly say that. And it's funny because some of the reasons certain people aren't called by the leader have nothing to do with music. Sometimes I'm like okay this gig is here and they don't drive. You know what I mean? Or this gig is here and in order to use them I'm going to have to do this, oh I can't fly them from there. You know? So you think about all these other things that, I mean don't really have anything to do with the music, before you get to the music. You know. Like sometimes before I decide what I'm going to play on certain gigs, I have to wait until I get the band members together. It's not that I'm not going to play, but certain tunes I would prefer to play with certain people. It's a whole different ballgame. And some of it has nothing to do with the desire to — your musical

thing. If you really want to do this, you know, I look at it and I see out of 365 days in the year what are Orrin Evans gigs and what are sideman gigs. And I was like obviously if I'm a leader I've got to get more and more gigs as Orrin Evans.

MR: Are there other considerations for you when you're hiring side people beyond their music capabilities?

OE: Yep. I mean just the ones like just getting there, the easiness to work with, you know. And really, to be honest, I haven't had too many bad experiences with hiring people that I don't get along with because I can figure out what makes them happy and try to meet them there you know. I've got a bunch of different personalities that I'm around on and off the bandstand. And I love managing those. So that's another part of, like if you're not — some people don't want to do that. To me sometimes it's fun to see — like hire the drummer that talks too much and you hire the bassist that is super quiet and an introvert and just watch how that goes down. So sometimes that part is fun to me too.

MR: Right. I've had people, when you get those two people who love to talk so much, like as soon as the song ends they start talking.

OE: Exactly.

MR: Oh man that's very interesting. Tell me about the — I want to follow-up on something from your website and you talked about the "barber shop" in the African-American community. And I've heard just a little bit about that, but can you expand on that at all?

OE: I mean that was, for me that was the place where I learned most things. You know, the time I would go to the barber shop, and for us, since I was the young one, I was the youngest, my brother would drop me off at the barber shop and if there were ten people in front of me and then he would come back, but he might, you know, he'd come back a little later. So I could honestly be in the barber shop for two to three hours on a Saturday just sitting there listening to the conversation. Or they would put on a movie and talk about the movie. So one of my first jobs, that was what I did. I swept hair in the barber shop. And I learned so much you know. Six barbers in there, all different ages, not all men — there were men and women — barbers not, women barbers also in there. And they were different religions, different musical and food taste. There was so much food I tasted for the first time at the barber shop because I would run and get food for people. So one barber wanted it just — I had never had chicken gizzards at that time. And he ordered chicken gizzards all the time. So I would run and get those you know. Or this one wants a sandwich this way. It was life. But it also, for me, how it helped me, I learned how there were so many different people in the barber shop, but then there were also people who didn't — they were in their little stations. You know like I said, this one only had chicken gizzards every Saturday. This one took a sandwich the same way every week. This one would always sweep his own hair, so I would never have anything to do because he

would sweep, he was like a neat freak. So what I learned, I was like I want to be a combination of everyone I meet. I want to grab little things from everybody. But I don't want to be so particular, you know, that I can't do this if it's not this way. And I learned sitting in the barber shop, I did see a lot of that. All the arguments were people were just stuck on their way. So you know, as far as learning from each person it was amazing but I also learned how to open myself up based on the closeness I saw in each station if that makes sense.

MR: Was it exclusively an African-American clientele?

OE: Oh yeah, without a doubt. Yeah.

MR: What about the neighborhood you were in in Philadelphia?

OE: Well two different barber shops really influenced me because the first one was in Trenton, New Jersey when I lived there. That's where I'm originally from. So that was like a middle class black neighborhood and the barber knew everyone. It was the place where I would get dropped off. It was like daycare. And you'd wait, there wasn't no cell phone or texting your mom or dad saying are you coming. No. You just sat there and you waited. You know? And then the one in Philadelphia was in an area called west of Blaine, a predominantly middle class black neighborhood. So I mean for me it was really what I needed, just even the male role models that were there — male and female — but you know, at that time my brother was living in New Jersey. My brother is ten years older than me. So I had my uncle at home but my uncle, my mother is the youngest of sixteen. So all my uncles were old to me, like very old. You know, when you're eleven and they're like seventy — a lot of my mom's — at that time. So the barber shop also helped fill that void you know. There were just so many cool people I met there.

MR: Did you see your uncle operating on gigs?

OE: Um hum. Yeah. But an ironic interesting story. The day we moved to Philadelphia, it was a quick move. So we got to my uncle's house and we were going to move in with my uncle. He was on the road. And so we were there for two days with him not being there, which was a little weird for me because you didn't want to touch anything, you're just sitting around. When he came home I was sitting there in the middle of the floor watching TV. So he came in with his saxophone. And I hadn't really discovered — I played the piano but I hadn't fallen in love with music yet. And he came in with his piano player and he looked at me and I looked back at him. He was like, "Here, put this in my room." And it was his saxophone. So I took the saxophone and I just walked it back to his room. My uncle never played the saxophone again. He ended up getting diagnosed with cancer and never played again. And from that he lost his teeth so he never played — I never heard my uncle play the saxophone again from that moment. But I fell in love with music that next month when I started at the new school. So I always look at it like he was

handing that over to me. And I mean that was — he didn't even pass until '95 and that was maybe '86, so ten years he struggled with it, but he wouldn't play, which was so weird to me because I was falling in love with music at the time and you know, I'm like how could you not play? But then I also under — he would sit down and play the piano and it was so great when he did, I would turn off everything. But you couldn't act like you were listening you know what I mean? You just walked and go somewhere else and you'd check him out. So that whole process was really special to me, and I'll always remember that it was like, "Here, take this to the room." And whatever was on — mojo was on that saxophone, you know, jumped on me, and I really got into music from that point.

MR: A quote from you: "Certain people have forced me to wake up and face my evolution." It sounds like you needed to be prodded to move ahead into something new? I don't want to read too much into that, but I thought it was a very interesting statement.

OE: Well there are certain people who introduced me to things that I may not have been checking out musically. And certain people came along and said look, if you really want to evolve as a complete piano player you might want to check this out. You know? You don't need to have one Ornette Coleman record, you should have them all you know. And so I had to really deal with that you know, and make sure I was evolving. Because it's so funny, it's so easy to be in the barber shop, you know? And just say this is how I am. This is how I am, this is what I play, this is what I eat, this is what I do. And meanwhile there's so much else you know, out there to check out. So you know certain people, along with people in the barber shop, really put that in me, to constantly evolve you know. And even now, driving here today, you realize you need that little push. And I'm like okay I've been doing the same thing for two months straight. I need to change it up, you know, whatever it is.

MR: What's the same thing?

OE: Well for me, you know, it could be driving the same way, the same direction. So now I'll put, every once in a while, where does this street go? And put the GPS on. And that's kind of how I like to approach life. It's the only way to evolve. Really food, everything. There's nothing — and people say what is your favorite — I don't know if I have too many favorites. I mean I love jazz and maybe it's my favorite type of music. Maybe. Maybe. But other than that, I don't have a real favorite color. I don't drink brown liquor so maybe that's one, I just don't but that's because I shouldn't.

MR: There's a good reason not to.

OE: But I just constantly try to try new whatever, new things. And that's what that's about. Evolving.

MR: There's a tune or a video on your website, I believe it was "Beauty" it came from that. And the trio is in a club and I don't know what the tune was but near the end you guys started playing. I think you started this thing. And the rhythm was like [scats]. And the first time you played it the other guys were not playing it with you. And the second time they started playing with you. And by the third time or so it became this thing and when people got to the end of the lick everybody stopped and there was this glorious silence. And you did it a few times, and then you ended. And I don't have a question here except that it was really effective and I guess I wondered did that happen on the fly?

OE: If it's what I think you're talking about, no. I mean it could have been called on on the fly, but it's a part of a conversation that the people in the band were used to having. I don't know if you remember this little skit on "Sesame Street" and it would say [scats]. That's really, if you know "Manamana" then you know to go [scats]. It's a tune of mine that if everyone knows, we play it together. And it's interesting because everybody, you know, sometimes the drummer may not know it and the bass player knows it so you end up playing, and, "Oh okay, got it." You know but it's a tune I wrote in college. It's called "Dorm Life" it's just a blues. But it's another title on a few other records called "When It Comes" and basically that's the reason — the business reason — the first version of the song was on a record label that took the artist's publishing. So when I did it on another song I re-named it. You'll see that a lot on certain artists where you're like well why does it have two titles? Because you're trying to get your song back. Yep.

MR: You've done a lot of recordings under your own name and I wonder if there's another disconnect like the different labels you've worked with say, "Hey that last thing was effective, do another one like that." And you want to maybe move on, evolve.

OE: I have a very interesting take on that. Well, I think it's interesting. But for me, you know, I have my own label. So when I do some of the things on my own label then I'm more of a stickler or sticking to what I want. Like this is the artwork I want, this is the engineer I want. But if I do it on a label I kind of go with the flow of the producer. Because as long as I'm not, as long as I'm not playing a type of music I don't like playing, or playing a certain way. But I figure what's most important was to get the record out there. So for a lot of those records, my early records, it was more about me joining the forces of the executive producer or producer, and saying okay cool. Because that's another way — if I went into the studio all the time with just this is the way I want to do it I'm not evolving. So I'm kind of, when I say an interesting take on it, I'm really open to what other people say in the studio as far as the producer and stuff. So I'll finish the record, go home and never, I don't really deal with edits, I let someone else do it. I'll let someone else mix them. I don't need to be a part of that. The part that I wanted to be a part of was making the music. So if you see it going this way a little bit okay cool. As long as you don't —

there are some limitations you know. And I've never had — each label has been, "What do you want to do?" So it may be a different instrumentation. You know maybe it's like, "Have you ever thought about recording with a bass clarinet?" No I didn't, that'd be cool. But if I hadn't, I would have never thought about it. So I'm open to the other — and a lot of artists — a lot of artists may not be. But that's also another — I also look at life like this, like this is now, I've got another one. You know what I mean? It's not that deep. It's really not that deep. It's just like when people go to the, "We'll go to that restaurant next week. It's okay. We can do it."

MR: It's still going to be there.

OE: It's still going to be there. So I put this record out and the next one I'm like all right I want to do it like that you know. And the main thing is to have product when you get to these venues and people want to buy your product. So if you're stuck arguing with a label, and you don't have a product and — that's more important. So figure out a way to get the product.

MR: Okay here's a maybe fictional scenario. You're at a dinner party and people are talking about what they do, and the person across the table learns you're a jazz musician and they say, "What are you thinking about when you go on and on?" Not you specifically, but jazz musicians, they go on and on and they don't have any music in front of them. What's going on?

OE: I mean honestly having the music in front of them doesn't mean the music wasn't there, it's just at one point they just memorized it which some people are like, "You didn't have any music." Yeah but I had to have some music at one point and I've just memorized it to make things easier. That's one point that I would probably say to that person. The other thing, sometimes it's just understanding the idea of improvisation. So some people don't understand that. They think improvisation is, which there are types of free improvisation — but they don't fully understand what improv is. And sometimes what is so annoying is trying to have a musical conversation with someone who's not a musician. And when they ask that question, that's a musical question and now I have to, you know it's like I'm not asking you about drywall. I just say it looks nice. So don't ask me the awkward musician question because I'm the only one sitting here. Ask something else like let's just have a normal conversation. So that's what I would be feeling inside. But I probably would just say I don't know what I would —

MR: That's one of the best responses I've gotten. No one's ever mentioned drywall before. But I know what you mean. It's — I love the magic in art. And sometimes when you go to great lengths to try to explain it, personally, for me, you take some of the magic out of it.

OE: Yeah.

MR: There's been a lot of instances over the years in jazz where one player gets replaced by another. You know, Red Garland and Wynton Kelly and then Bill Evans and so forth. And I've noticed a bit of press about you joining the Bad Plus and it seems to be worthy of press. How do you feel about stepping into a group that's been together for, you know, quite a few years.

OE: Well first, everything, not everything, sorry let me take that back. First there's a lot of things out there that are worthy of press that just don't get it. And one of those things could be Orrin Evans you know. I've been here twenty years doing this. And now there's tons of press about me joining the Bad Plus. Now there's promoters and agents that want to call up. Or now, every advertisement, even one for this one is like "the Bad Plus pianist." They even had to put the picture of the Bad Plus up on the advertisement. You know? So like I am enjoying this new journey in my life and I love playing with Dave and Reid, and I'm really happy to be a part of the Bad Plus. But the one thing I have to keep in mind, and I think everyone, I'm going to be doing this ten years from now, the Bad Plus, and we'll all have stopped talking about it but hopefully just coming out to gigs still. Hopefully coming out and buying a record. You know it's kind of like when, you know the special thing about it is that this band has been almost twenty years and never had a personnel change. Never. So it's really special to me to be that first personnel change and last personnel change. It's really special for me to be a part of it. But it's also important, and this sounds so — I hear it in my head — it's just also important for me, for everyone to know I've been here you know? I've been here and I said to someone in an interview I said at least I'm a good publicist. Because someone said, "Hey, how are you going to do the Bad Plus, you're super busy." I'm like one I'm not super busy, but I'm glad that you think I'm super busy because I've been putting that energy out there and advertising myself along with my wife and the website. So it's really great that you thought that. So I look at it right now as just a beautiful thing that's happening. I've never been on the road and enjoyed it as much as I've enjoyed this, outside of another co-led group I'm in called Tarbaby with Eric Revis and Nasheet Waits, I have never felt this home, like I'm home. And it really does feel good. And now, I mean we've got, since January, so two or three months under our belt of touring and we're going out again. And we're playing for the first time in New York next week, which is a little intimidating you know, for me. But I'm looking forward to it. But Bad Plus has some dedicated fans. And some of them are funny, you know, they'll tell you right out how they feel if you play the song a little different than what they're used to. So it's really cool. It's getting me and my memory and my — it's been a great experience. And it's going to be fun to play in New York. But it's also a little undaunting you know.

MR: I saw the trio some time ago, before you joined. And often times during the concert I was mystified as to where are they. And then all of a sudden, bam they would come together on a lick or something and I said well they knew where they were. Or that they were either visually or that there was some kind of cue. And it seemed like a very — everybody had 33 percent in that group. Is that the way that you —

OE: Definitely. Definitely. Definitely. I mean I — being the new member, it wasn't that I walked right in and took my shoes off and laid on the couch. I didn't do that. I came in and I asked where the plates were, where the knives were, and is it okay if I put this — you know and I'm still doing a bit of that. You know? Because it is a new house for me to come visit. But over the last couple of weeks you know, I realize it's not a visit anymore, I'm home, and I'm starting to figure out where I want to put stuff you know. And that that's, that's a journey. That's a journey. And there's going to be moments where I put stuff right here and then Reid may come along and say no we put this over here, you know? And I can either, at that point, say well I like it here, is it okay? Shall we try this? Or is it really important for it to be over here? And then Dave will come over and he's like I don't care where you two put it. You know?

MR: Perfect. All right. I'll wrap up with, this is an easy question. What do you think of the state of our country right now?

OE: That's easy? You said wrap up with an easy question? I'm not as scared, I don't think it's changed that much, that everyone is like this is getting out of hand. I don't think it's really getting out of hand. You know? I think social media and cell phones put us in a place where we see it way more. We see, you don't have that time to hide. You know you could do something crazy, you could do something outlandish and crazy in 1992 and everyone would say did you see what such-and-such did? Yeah. And then it's done the next day. 'Cause there's no proof of it. There's no phone. There's only this story that everyone's telling. So you know as a black man I was pulled over — and thank God I haven't in years — but I was pulled over many-a-times and felt unsafe. You know? I just didn't have a phone to record it and I just didn't get home and put it on social media you know. And I believe — there are these horrible school shootings happening before Columbine, but it wasn't that broadcast. So right now, my whole point in saying that is I don't think we're in a state where the world is getting worse, we're just getting in a state where everyone's seeing it and now it's time we need to do something about it you know. It's not — it's been going on. It's been going on. So now we have to do something about it. But when you have the hierarchy that we do have in the situations that we do have now it's going to be difficult. It's going to be extremely difficult. You know? Because now with that cell phone, with that FaceBook and we have also given voices to a lot of people who were silent, which is not that, to me that's great, now we see you, now we see you.

Now we can deal with it. You know? I got on the elevator the other day, someone said to me, we were in Germany and they said, "Man, do you ever feel weird." And I was like, "Why?" They said, "Because I just swear all these people, every time they're walking by they're looking at you and do you ever feel weird that they're just looking at you because you're black?" And the Eagles had just won the Super Bowl so I came back and I had this big Eagles shirt on and a sweat suit that looked like I was from a reject Run-DMC movie. So I said, "I think they're looking at me because I have this Eagles jersey and this reject sweat suit on." And he laughed. But the point is I don't even, you know, I don't see that. And in that same conversation he was like, "How is it to be the only black person, you know, here?" I never really, now I consciously look, I'm like wait, I've been the only black person for the last four hours and I've seen a bunch of people. You know? But I guess my whole point of even bringing that up is this is the world I live in and I don't plan on moving to a different world so I'm trying to figure out the best way to navigate my time here you know, and navigate my time where I enjoy every moment of it. And the biggest part of me is the fact that I'm not a jazz musician, it's that I'm a black man. So I embrace that and I walk in this world just like everyone else. You know? I walk in this world just like everyone else. And once we all start to really embrace that I honestly think this will be a better world. You know? We can't get through a lot of, you know, even driving here, honestly, there was about a good thirty mile stretch where I was like Lord if my car breaks down I'm not going anywhere near any of these houses and seeing anyone. So they're out there. They're out there. But we've got to — we have to be aware and stop honestly giving everybody their 15 seconds, 16 seconds of fame, and just really deal with the problem. That was a whole bunch of shit but hopefully it made sense.

MR: No, it made great sense. And I appreciate you sharing it, and I can't think of a better way to wrap this up. And I wish you the best with your career and your kids and your family and so forth.

OE: Thank you very much.

MR: Thank you.